I’m telling you this so that you know why, up until 6 November 2008, I didn’t see any reason to stop drinking. I mean, why should I? I was having a lot of fun, and getting slaughtered only seemed to improve my batting. But obviously that was not a healthy attitude. Things had to change …

My road to rehab began when Mickey Arthur and acting team manager Doc Moosajee sat me down on that November day. Mickey wasted no time in getting to the point: ‘Hersch, I think you need to get some help.’ I protested that I was fine, that everything was under control, and that I wasn’t drinking any more than the other guys. Mickey wasn’t buying it, though – he’d obviously seen enough by then. ‘Hersch,’ he said, ‘this is your ultimatum: You either get help, or you don’t play for South Africa again. We need you to sort this out.’

I’ll never forget that conversation; it was the day before the first ODI against Bangladesh during their tour to South Africa in October/November. The three of us were sitting in the changing room at the Wanderers gym and I was being given an ultimatum, because what had transpired two nights earlier had been the last straw.

On the Tuesday, we had had an early team meeting at about one or two in the afternoon, which meant that for the rest of the day we had nothing scheduled – no team dinner or any reason to get up early the next morning. The T20 game against Bangladesh was scheduled for the next day, starting at 6 p.m. I had time on my hands and I was in a hotel. Not always a good combination when you happen to be me.

I called up a girl, a friend I hadn’t seen for a while, and had a couple of glasses of wine with her in the hotel bar. She left at about 3 p.m., so I phoned another young lady and told her to come around. And all the time I kept drinking. Unfortunately, I hadn’t had anything to eat, and the wine was beginning to hit me. Later a few mates joined me as well, and some shooters were ordered … and that’s when things start to get very hazy. By now it was around 7 p.m. and I had been drinking for about five hours, on an empty stomach.

I’m embarrassed to admit that I also got aggressive that night – I was later told that I had verbally abused my teammate Monde Zondeki, who was there with mates from Joburg, as well as some other people in the bar. Apparently, I had been completely out of line. Normally I’m not at all aggressive or obnoxious when I get drunk, but rather subdued and quiet.